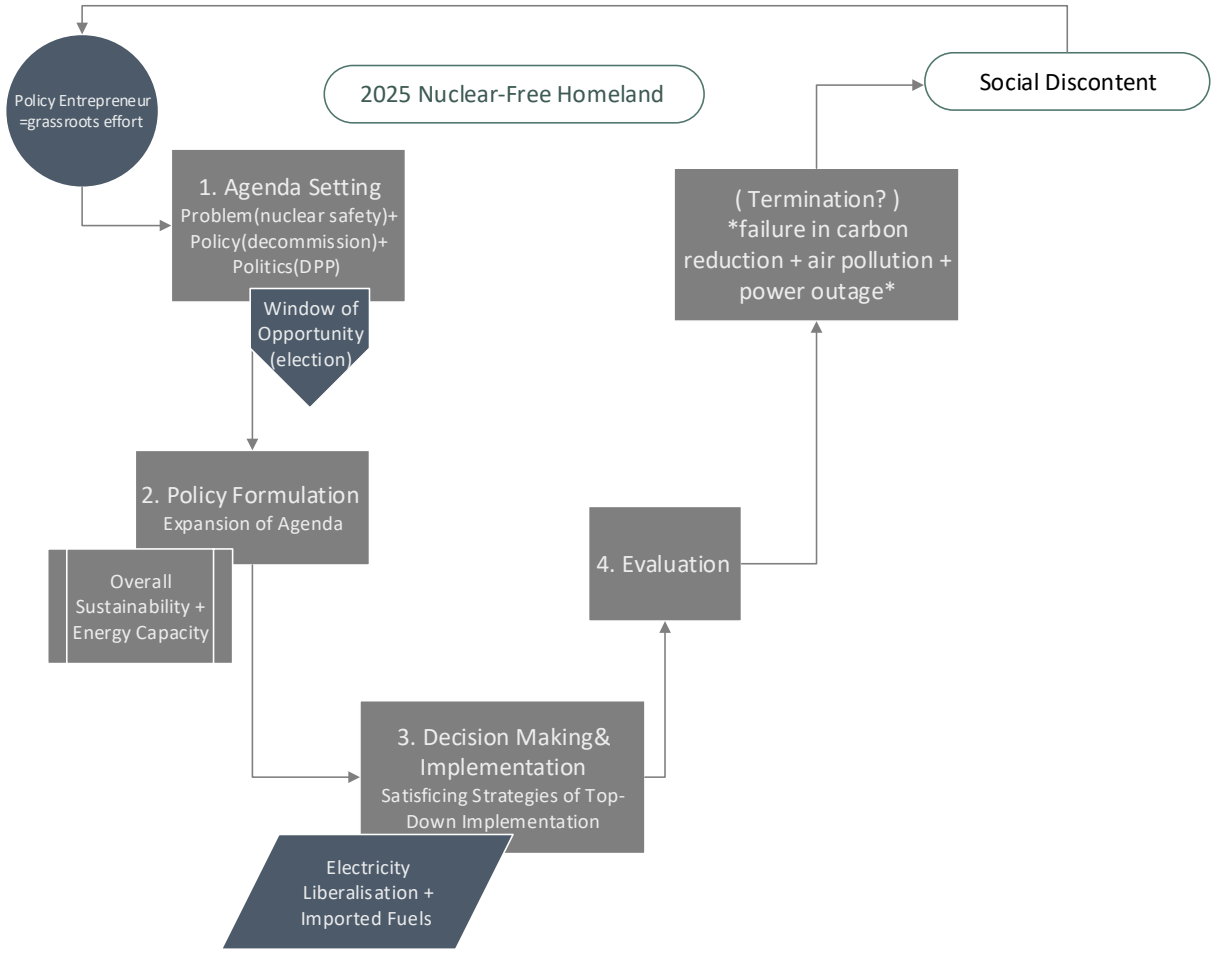
Tracing the Nuclear-Free Homeland Policy in Taiwan Through the Policy Cycle



1. Agenda Setting

Taiwan's *Nuclear Free Homeland* (NFH)policy is critical in spurring democratization and bolstering support for the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP) in Taiwan[1]. Fueled by environmentalism and post-Fukushima fears, protests and a referendum, through policy entrepreneurs, brought the issue to the forefront. Kingdon's framework in agenda setting posits that the convergence of problem, policy, and politics streams opens a "window of opportunity."[2] In this case, grassroots policy entrepreneurs and the DPP halted the construction of a fourth nuclear power plant under the Kuomintang (KMT), establishing decommissioning as the preferred alternative, and solidified after the DPP won the election.

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[1] Gillan Chi-Lun Huang, Rung-Yi Chen, and Byung-Bae Park, "Democratic Innovations as a Party Tool: A Comparative Analysis of Nuclear Energy Public Participation in Taiwan and South Korea," *Energy Policy* 153 (2021): 112251, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.enpol.2021.112251.

[2] Scott Greer, "John W. Kingdon, Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies," in Martin Lodge, Edward C. Page, and Steven J. Balla (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Classics in Public Policy and Administration* (Oxford Handbooks, 2015).

2. Policy Formulation

Initially focused solely on NFH, the DPP broadened its targets to include emission reduction, renewable energy (RE) development, and overall sustainability. While decommissioning was already on track, the policymakers needed to address the subsequent energy shortfall.[3] Policy formulation involves extending to objective specification and design.[4] In this case, policymakers redefined the nuclear issue from a purely technical problem into a multifaceted challenge that facilitated a competitive electricity market, ensuring a sustainable transition.

3. Decision Making& Implementation

In the NFH policy, decision making and implementation occur as a tightly integrated, top-down process. Under bounded rationality, policymakers "muddle through" by adopting incremental, satisficing strategies to reconcile nuclear decommissioning with energy security.[5] Legislative reforms in early 2017 mandated nuclear shutdowns, while concurrent efforts to promote electricity liberalisation sought to spur RE growth. However, rapid decommissioning led to power outages and increased reliance on imported fuels, indicating that these top-down measures have not yet produced a fully diversified, [6] sustainable energy system.[7]

4. Evaluation& Termination?

Through Vedung's evaluation framework,[8] persistent challenges—recurring outages, high air pollution, and supply instability—have hindered the achievement of carbon reduction targets[9]. These adverse outcomes raise critical questions about the policy's long-term viability Geva-May's termination theory suggests that organizational inertia and prohibitive termination costs may eventually necessitate a radical policy reconsideration if these adverse outcomes persist, a possibility increasingly signaled by the KMT.[10]

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[3] Gao, Anton Ming-Zhi, Chien-Te Fan, and Chao-Ning Liao. 2018. "Application of German Energy Transition in Taiwan: A Critical Review of Unique Electricity Liberalisation as a Core Strategy to Achieve Renewable Energy Growth." *Energy Policy* 120: 644–654. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.enpol.2018.01.010.

[4] Turnpenny, John R., Andrew J. Jordan, David Benson, and Tim Rayner. 2015. "The Tools of Policy Formulation: An Introduction." In *The Tools of Policy Formulation*, Edward Elgar Publishing, 3–30.

[5] Forester, John. 1984. "Bounded Rationality and the Politics of Muddling Through." *Public Administration Review* 44 (1984): 23–31.

[6] Yang, Fang, Jie Dian, and Zihan Liu. 2022. "Can Taiwan's '2025 Non-Nuclear Homeland' Policy Achieve the Expected Carbon Emission Reduction Goals?" *Journal of Cleaner Production* 380: 134995. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jclepro.2022.134995.

[7] DeLeon, Peter, and Linda DeLeon. 2002. "What Ever Happened to Policy Implementation? An Alternative Approach." *Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory* 12, no. 4 (2002): 467–492.

[8] Vedung, Evert. 2017. *Public Policy and Program Evaluation*. Routledge, Chapter 5.

[9] Yang et al., "Nuclear-Free Homeland," 134995.

[10] Geva-May, Iris. 2001. "When the Motto Is 'Till Death Do Us Part': The Conceptualization and the Craft of Termination in the Public Policy Cycle." (2001): 263–288.

Taiwan's nuclear-free homeland policy exemplifies the complex interplay of agenda setting, formulation, decision making, and implementation within a highly top-down governance structure. The ongoing evaluation reveals that while incremental measures have been pragmatic, persistent operational challenges may ultimately compel policymakers to reconsider or even terminate the policy, prompting a critical re-examination of Taiwan's energy transition strategy in the future.

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